ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Modal perfects

Modal perfects look backwards. The event is in the past, while the modal shows how certain, surprised or critical the speaker is now.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Express conclusions, possibilities and evaluations about the past.

Use modal + have + past participle to infer, criticise or consider possibilities about completed events.

MODEL

She must have left early. / You should have called.

modal + have + past participle

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Make past deductions with different degrees of certainty.

OUTCOME 2

02

Express criticism or regret with should have.

OUTCOME 3

03

Separate strong conclusions, open possibilities and logical impossibility.

Build meaning before form

Use modal + have + past participle to infer, criticise or consider possibilities about completed events.

A certainty scale for past events

Modal perfects do not change the event; they reveal the speaker's interpretation of it. Must have presents the evidence as highly convincing, while might have keeps competing explanations open.

Can't have is the negative end of the deduction scale: the available facts make the proposed explanation impossible.

Assessment	Form
almost certain	must have
possible	might/may/could have
impossible	can't/couldn't have

Why should have is not a deduction

Should have evaluates an action that did not happen, or did not happen as expected. You should have checked the figures normally implies that the figures were not checked and a negative consequence followed.

Context decides whether the tone sounds like advice, disappointment, criticism or regret.

Evidence controls the modal

Begin with the evidence, not the grammar. A locked door may support can't have entered; a missing coat may support must have left; uncertainty about a route may call for might have taken.

A responsible speaker selects the strength of the modal in proportion to the strength of the evidence.

Pronunciation does not change spelling

In rapid speech, have is often reduced, but it remains have in writing. Could of and should of are spelling errors caused by the sound of the contractions could've and should've.

The grammatical sequence is always modal + have + past participle.

02 · VISUAL MAP

Reason through the pattern

The meter separates strong deduction, open possibility, impossibility and retrospective criticism. Evidence moves the pointer; the modal names the speaker's judgement.

01	02	03
modal	have	past participle

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use can't or couldn't have for logical impossibility.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Form	Meaning	Example
must have	strong deduction	He must have forgotten.
might have	possibility	She might have missed the train.
can’t have	impossibility	They can’t have seen us.
should have	criticism/regret	You should have told me.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

must have left	strong conclusion
might have left	possibility
can’t have left	impossibility
should have left	criticism

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using had after the modal.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using mustn’t have instead of can’t have for negative deduction.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using the base form instead of the past participle.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

The lights are off and her coat is gone. She ___ home.

OPTIONS must have gone · should go · must went · can have go

A2 · CONTEXT 2

I am not certain, but the message ___ into spam.

OPTIONS might have gone · must go · should went · can't have go

A3 · CONTEXT 3

Ben was abroad, so he ___ the accident.

OPTIONS can't have seen · must have seen · should see · might saw

A4 · CONTEXT 4

You ___ a backup before deleting the folder.

OPTIONS should have made · must make · might made · can't have make

A5 · CONTEXT 5

The parcel is not here. The courier ___ the wrong address.

OPTIONS may have used · may used · should use · must to use

A6 · CONTEXT 6

She got every answer right. She ___ very hard.

OPTIONS must have studied · must studied · should study · can't have studied

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

They _____ the invitation, or they _____ the date.

OPTIONS Gap 1: might not have received / might not received / must not receive · Gap 2: could have forgotten / could forgot / should forgetting

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

The figures _____ correct; the totals do not match. Someone _____ a formula incorrectly.

OPTIONS Gap 1: can't have been / must have been / should be · Gap 2: must have entered / must entered / might enter

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

We _____ earlier; we _____ the last train.

OPTIONS Gap 1: should have left / must have left / should left · Gap 2: would not have missed / would not miss / had not missed

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

The file is no longer on the server. Ana _____ it because she had no access. Leo _____ it by mistake, but we are not sure. The automatic cleanup _____ it; the log shows a deletion at midnight. We _____ the retention settings before the update, and we _____ a separate backup.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

can’t have deleted · can’t remove · might have removed · might keeping · might removed · must have checked · must have deleted · must have removed · must remove · ought kept · ought to have kept · should checked · should delete · should have checked · should remove

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

The door was locked, so the visitor _____ (impossible/enter) through it. She _____ (possible/use) the side entrance. The guard recognised her, so they _____ (deduction/meet) before. We _____ (criticism/check) the camera footage sooner. The timestamp _____ (possible/be) wrong.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 1. Include must have forgotten.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 2. Include might have sent, may have sent, could have sent.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 3. Include should have checked, ought to have checked.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Correct: He must had taken the wrong bus.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 1. Include must have, might have, can’t have.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 2. Include should have.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Modal perfects response for context 3. Include may have, must have.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: modal.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: have.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: past participle.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: intention.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

must have gone

Use “must have gone”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

A2

might have gone

Use “might have gone”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

A3

can’t have seen

Use “can’t have seen”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

A4

should have made

Use “should have made”. Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

A5

may have used

Use “may have used”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

A6

must have studied

Use “must have studied”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

might not have received / could have forgotten

Use “might not have received”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence. Use “could have forgotten”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

B2

can’t have been / must have entered

Use “can’t have been”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible. Use “must have entered”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

B3

should have left / would not have missed

Use “should have left”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility. Use “would not have missed”. Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

can’t have deleted

Use “can’t have deleted”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

C2

might have removed

Use “might have removed”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

C3

must have removed

Use “must have removed”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

C4

should have checked

Use “should have checked”. Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

C5

ought to have kept

Use “ought to have kept”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

can’t have entered

Use “can’t have entered”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

D2

might have used

Use “might have used”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

D3

must have met

Use “must have met”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

D4

should have checked

Use “should have checked”. Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

D5

might have been

Use “might have been”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

Julia must have forgotten the meeting.

Use “Julia must have forgotten the meeting.”. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

E2

They might have sent the document to another address.

Use “They might have sent the document to another address.”. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

E3

We should have checked the source.

Use “We should have checked the source.”. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

E4

He must have taken the wrong bus.

Use “He must have taken the wrong bus.”. Use should or ought to have for an unfulfilled expectation or retrospective criticism.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

She must have left early, she might have felt ill, and she can’t have taken the car.

The model combines accurate Modal perfects with a clear purpose. Use must have for a conclusion strongly supported by evidence.

F2

We should have tested the form and should have informed users earlier.

The model combines accurate Modal perfects with a clear purpose. Use might, may or could have when several explanations remain possible.

F3

The server stopped at midnight. It may have overheated, but someone must have restarted it.

The model combines accurate Modal perfects with a clear purpose. Use can’t or couldn’t have for logical impossibility.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____